

Thurmaston: an Industrial Village shaped by Framework Knitting

Jennifer Harris

Towards the end of the seventeenth century, seventy years before the Enclosures of 1763 dramatically changed the physical landscape. Thurmaston was undergoing its own metamorphosis. Whether by choice, chance or circumstance, the village was turning towards an irreversible industrial legacy, a world away from the self-sufficient agricultural existence that had up until then been the mainstay of the hamlets of Thurmaston North and South.

Just three miles away along the Fosse Way, the county town of Leicester, had already woken up to a new trade in knitted hose, and it did not take long for those in Thurmaston with the necessary means, to take the initiative and apprentice their sons to what looked like a promising business. Leicestershire, with its flocks of long-wool sheep, was well-placed to provide the fine worsted yarn, well-suited for the production of wrought stockings, shaped and fashioned on the frame, and then stitched by hand into a well-finished product.

By 1700, frames were being worked in the village, and records of the 1720s show that local boys such as Thomas Smith in 1722 and Thomas Swan in 1728, were being apprenticed in the well-established hosiery workshops such as Widdowson's in nearby Wanlip. After seven years, such apprentices expected to gain the status of Freeman, with the prospect of conducting their own business

and taking in their own apprentices in their own village. Thus began Thurmaston's industrial heritage, initially affecting the better off, but with the coming of the Enclosures which dealt their blow against the landless villager, it exploded into an enterprise that encompassed virtually the entire village for almost another two hundred years.

Transport improvements towards the latter part of the eighteenth century significantly aided these developments, with the opening of the lucrative Loughborough to Leicester

branch of the canal network in 1794, and new turnpike roads, providing better access for the supply and transport of finished products. The world was opening up to the framework knitter in terms of demand and opportunity and Thurmaston was duly following suit. What the village may have lacked in visual attraction, it was gaining in industrial amenities.

The village also saw the opening of a brick and tile works, exploiting a clay pit to the east of the Fosse Way, supplying work to some, and materials

to others. New three-storey houses were constructed, large windows on the upper floors allowing maximum light for the framework knitters. These buildings supplemented the older farm buildings along the main street, which were increasingly being split into multiple dwellings, with Thurmaston having few resident Georgian gentry.



Aerial view of Thurmaston North, c.1960, showing a row of early three-storey FWK cottages on the main street, now demolished. A derelict workshop can be seen to their right, another now modernised late frameshop to its right, plus further right, a small early shop between cottages round the corner in Canal Street. (Photograph courtesy of Mrs Winterton.)

By 1801, the population of Thurmaston was 706, comprising essentially a working class with few still tied to agriculture. The parish registers show that most were involved in the hosiery business. Initially, men operated the heavy knitting machines. Hours were long and when daylight was insufficient, candles had to be lit and eyes strained until the required quota of knitwear was reached. Women and children assisted by seaming and winding.



Corner of Hadrian Road, two early three-storey FWK houses with later additions to left, forming a yard entered through passageway, c.1910. (Photograph courtesy of Thurmaston Print Shop.)

Residents from neighbouring villages, such as William Sarson from Queniborough and William Toon from Syston, aware of this trend and in need of a new way to support their families, were moving in and adding to Thurmaston's population. Charles Foister of Rearsby arrived as a carpenter, but his offspring were to become framework knitters. Some of the incomers worked in tiny garden workshops, often attached to the houses of already established hosiers like Joseph Towe, a Freeman since 1789 and William Pymm, who was taking apprentices by 1790. Others rented frames and relied on a hierarchy of middlemen to supply materials and payment for their stockings, living in little clusters and communities along the main street in cheap housing often provided by the entrepreneur who raked in profit at every opportunity. Those with savings would invest in a frame, then collect their own yarn and return the finished articles to the big hosiers' warehouses in Leicester. Unmarried men could also live-in with an employer as journeymen. Whatever their situation however, the system was still one of a cottage industry, based on a villager working in his own home or that of a master, serving and relying on another for his livelihood. In that respect, very little had changed from pre-enclosure subservience.

However, the initial expansion of the framework knitting industry in the late eighteenth century was soon dealt several heavy blows. Wars on the American continent, while of little interest to the poorly-educated Thurmaston framework knitter, affected him nonetheless by disturbing foreign trade, producing food shortages and a rise in prices of virtually everything the stockinger needed. A previously good living dropped substantially. Women and young boys were put to work on the knitting frame in order to boost a family's income and they subsequently flooded the workforce. In contrast, war with France had the opposite effect. Demand for knitwear increased in order to supply the armies, while the number of workers reduced as husbands and sons joined the voluntary forces.

When fighting ceased, Thurmaston turned to producing socks in an effort to pull itself back from the brink. Fashions were changing, men preferring trousers to short breeches and women turning to longer skirts. Wrought stockings, the speciality of the local knitting frame, were no longer required in such great numbers; socks were the new commodity. Seasonal price problems still caused fluctuations in the market, but ever resourceful, Thurmaston's workforce delivered cotton goods during the summer and the more traditional worsted hose in the colder months.

Even the Luddite frame-breaking of new machinery, a serious occurrence in the East Midlands, did not tempt the Thurmaston villagers away from their determination to improve their standard of living. Neither did many become Chartists, forerunners of the trade unions. Thurmaston's only real growing concern was one of dissent against the established church, with the trend towards Methodism which had arrived in the village around 1777, offering a comfort and support that seemed lacking in the politics of the Chartists, and set the ordinary framework knitter apart from the employers, who on the whole were of the established church.

During the early part of the nineteenth century, the new wide knitting frame upon which several socks could be made at once, and the practice of making inferior products called 'cut-ups' (cutting the sock at heel or toe and stitching them into shape, a weaker article and often passed off as wrought) both reached Thurmaston, causing, as in many other villages at this time, an overproduction of both socks and sock makers.

The struggles of the 1820s and 1830s received some relief during the following decade. The Midland Counties Railway cut along the eastern boundary of the village, offering further opportunity for trade and also for workers to move between the various centres of employment.

Sand and gravel deposits were also being extracted from numerous pits within the village boundaries, which together with the presence of a further brickworks beside the railway at the northern end of Thurmaston provided further diversity for employment. The 1841 census shows the growth of new housing, and in the village, neat rows of new cottages would have contrasted with the earlier boom-era tiny back-to-back dwellings standing on badly drained ground. As late as 1883, the ordnance survey map reveals the slum houses, which still survived in areas known as the 'Dials' and the 'Marsh Yard'.

By 1844, Thurmaston had 400 frames in the village and a population of 1209. This number of frames was second only to the larger centres of Sileby and Wigston, and was nearly half the number of those being worked in the town of Loughborough, and a third of those in Shepshed. There were also four framesmiths with a journeyman and apprentice listed in the census, showing there was still a steady need for new machines and for the maintenance of those being used.

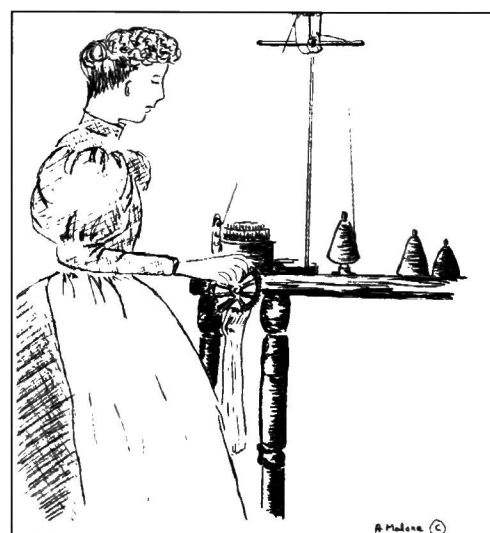
The following year, the inadequate diet, health, working and living conditions of the sock makers was highlighted in R.M. Muggeridge's 1845 'Report On The Condition Of Framework Knitters', and may have encouraged local squire Thomas Allen to donate land for allotments to help the workers feed their family. The squire also gave land for the building of a National School in order to provide the children of the framework knitters with an education, but payment of the fee was something that they could ill afford.

Two of the testimonies in the Muggeridge Report were actually from Thurmaston residents, and show their lives to be far from rosy. Both were dissenters. Walter Upton had tried and failed to interest people in the union movement and had, instead, joined with others to set up a Primitive Methodist Chapel. He told of his struggle to avoid the workhouse, turning to agriculture when trade was slack, and of payment by 'truck'. Thomas Hartshorn, a fellow sock-maker, was a Wesleyan Sunday school teacher. He had received one of the allotment gardens and was renting two frames from a village manufacturer; one worked by his son aged just nine.

Thurmaston's population dropped between 1851 and 1861, an examination of the census reports revealing a temporary exodus of young workers, with some seeking employment in nearby Nottinghamshire. For those who stayed, the contemporary boom in woollen glove-making allowed further diversification in the village. This, although requiring more skill, gave a better return for the work involved. This willingness to diversify is a key feature in Thurmaston's success in the hosiery industry during a climate of market fluctuations, poverty and discord that continually beleaguered the trade.

The following decade brought the national abolition of frame rents, which cut off a valuable source of income for the hosier and an Education Act, which effectively put a block on the availability of cheap child labour. Bag hosiers and other independent entrepreneurs were quick to exploit a new situation, building their own small framework knitters' workshops around the village. Work was more forthcoming if the knitter rented a frame within the shop, rather than struggle to maintain a living from one at home, even if served by a hosier. Conditions, however, were appalling. A row of machines would be packed back to back against each longer wall of these tiny oblong buildings, with the winding machines taking up most of the gangway between them. Long windows allowed as much daylight as possible to fall upon the knitters' work, but when this failed, candlelight, magnified by glass globes, had to suffice. With eight, ten or more frames on average in Thurmaston's new frameshops, the constant noise of metal against metal and the air full of wool or cotton fibre from the knitting process would have been oppressive. Factory Acts to relieve the situation were virtually unenforceable with too many small 'factories' to supervise.

The 1880s brought an improvement with two more brickworks along the railway at the south end, and at the north end the arrival of basket-makers, W. T. Ellmore & Son, adding a new dimension to the industrial scene, drawing workers from other villages as well as the local work-pool. A 'New Thurmaston' consisting of just two streets and two knitters' shops was built at the southernmost boundary with Belgrave. By the end of the decade there were at least eighteen of these newer frameshops throughout the village as well as a scattering of the old add-on or garden workshops.



A woman in the 1890s working with a circular Griswold sock-making machine, which is attached to a table. (Sketch courtesy of A. Malone.)

A great innovation for the knitting industry during the early 1890s was the small, circular Griswold sock-making machine. Patented in Leicester from an American invention,

nimble-fingered young women were especially useful for this type of advancement, which being easily portable could also be used for outwork in the home. Charles Foister, advertising in a parish magazine for Griswold operatives, built up a thriving business, and by 1901 the census reveals many young girls in this profession.

It was also a time of prosperity for Thurmaston. Main Street was updated with late Victorian housing and new side streets added, replacing most of the remaining cottages of wattle, daub and thatch. With many villagers now working outside of the home, these terraces no longer required the large windows of the framework knitter. Roads and pavements received regular dressings of gravel and granite. Poor sanitation, the cause of much death and disease, slowly improved, and gas lighting was introduced. Many new corner shops offered a superior quality of foodstuffs and provisions.

The ensuing war of 1914 took many workers away from Thurmaston, but also provided an additional market for both the knitter and the basket-maker. The forces required woollen socks and gloves, while Ellmore was able to supply baskets for shells and observation balloons.

As before, when conflict was over, the scene at home took a downturn. Fashions changed again, and too many people were chasing too few jobs. The town of Leicester was also drawing labour away from the village, especially to the rapidly growing boot and shoe industry, and to the better conditions within its larger hosiery factories. Thurmaston was now struggling to compete. Ever-present financial constraints prevented improvements to the old-fashioned small factory workshops. Only Ellmore had expanded, introducing steam power at the turn of the twentieth century.

A landmark water tower topped with a figure of Britannia, signalled the beginning of 'Britannia Works'. While the hosiers traded their underwear, Ellmore's cane and willow products were promoted and sold to ocean liners with showrooms opening around the country.

Only three of the old-style knitting firms were still operating by the end of the second decade of the twentieth century. When Charles Foister died in 1918, his business went to Leicester, where his two sons were already making a name for themselves. A second frameshop had branched into Argyle hose, a popular trend of the time, while gloves continued in another. By the 1930s, the knitting frame had breathed its last, although many Griswolds were still being used in the village for outwork until as late as the nineteen-fifties.

Thurmaston had to move with the times. It needed investment and opportunity, all of which came too slowly

and spasmodically to salvage a heritage, which had gripped the village for two hundred and fifty years. Fervour to improve at any cost spread post-war housing and commercial estates to the boundaries in all directions, obliterating many signs of previous history. For the past fifty or so years, various types of industry have come and gone, an assortment of smaller enterprises now punctuate the local landscape, with a large shopping centre dominating the north end.

Sadly, the community today bears little evidence of framework knitters' cottages and workshops, with those that remain being disguised by modern living. Even Ellmore's tower, a solitary symbol of a new age, was demolished in the name of progress after a mere eighty or so years. For Thurmaston, the picture from the 'chocolate box' has long since gone, but open that box, and an equally compelling heritage lies waiting for any who would care to look, an illustration of villagers showing fortitude and tenacity in their endeavour to overcome the hand that life had dealt them.



The end of Ellmore's 110-foot water tower 1982. The hosiery buildings have already gone. Only the old willow works now stands today but with a different use. (Photograph courtesy of Thurmaston Print Shop.)

Sources:

1. Thurmaston Census records 1841-1901.
2. Thurmaston Parish registers.
3. Thurmaston's Local Board Of Health 1880-1887.
4. *The Victoria History Of The Counties Of England: Leicestershire*. Vols. 3 and 4.
5. John Mansfield, *1819 Report From The Select Committee*.
6. R. M. Muggeridge, *Report On The Condition Of Framework Knitters 1845*.
7. H. Hartopp, *Register Of The Freeman Of Leicester 1196-1930*.

For further information about the story of Thurmaston and its Framework knitting heritage, look out for Jennifer Harris's forthcoming book entitled *A Stitch In Time Thurmaston's Forgotten Framework Knitters*.